BetweenKeys

BUSINESS SYSTEMS

Take your cell number off the internet

Why every business builder needs a business line, and how to choose who (or what) answers it when you can't

For agents, consultants, freelancers and entrepreneurs · Prices checked Nov 2026

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THE SHORT VERSION

Step one isn't optional. Get a business line and take your personal number off every public page.

Step two is a choice: who picks up that line when you're with a client, on a site visit or done for the day.

Where your number leaks

Agents

Listings, Zillow and Realtor.com profiles, MLS, yard signs, brokerage rosters.

Consultants

Proposals, vendor registrations, conference and training bios, course pages.

Freelancers and creatives

Invoices, portfolio sites, marketplace profiles, press kits.

Everyone

Google Business Profile, LinkedIn, email signatures, business cards.

Why your cell shouldn't be public

It gets scraped and sold

Search engines index it. Data brokers attach it to your home address and family.

It's a key to your accounts

In a SIM swap, a scammer gets your carrier to move your number, then resets your logins.

It invites the wrong callers

Spam, scams and people you never meant to give direct access to.

It outlives the business

A business line can be forwarded or shut off when you pivot or step back. Your cell keeps ringing.

Sources: Offlist privacy guide; FTC SIM swap guidance; Fairshake SIM swap guide

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FOR REAL ESTATE AGENTS, IT'S MEASURABLE

22%

feared for their personal safety or the safety of their personal information in 2024

86%

showed properties alone

You meet strangers alone.

A business line means they never have your personal number, the one that leads to your home address.

Source: National Association of REALTORS, 2024 Member Safety Residential Report

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Get a business line: pick one

Option	Good for	Watch out for
Google Voice	Free or cheap; rings your existing phone	Basic features; no AI answering; moving it later means porting
VoIP phone app Quo, Allo, RingCentral	Shared inbox for partners, texting, recording, AI answering add-ons	Per-user monthly fee; switching later means porting the number
Second cell plan	Simple; works anywhere	Second device or eSIM; no team sharing; moving it later means porting

Every option locks you in a little: switching providers later means porting the number (possibly for a fee), usually 1 to 2 weeks. So pick the line and the answering setup together.

Sources: Google Voice Help; Quo porting guide

Getting your number off the web

1. Get the business line live first. Don't pull your cell until it works.
2. Swap it on your website, Google Business Profile, LinkedIn and social bios.
3. Update directory and marketplace profiles: Zillow, vendor portals, Upwork and the like.
4. Fix the templates: proposals, invoices, email signature, cards.
5. Ask your carrier for a port-out PIN or number lock on your cell.
6. Move bank and email two-factor codes to an authenticator app.
7. Opt out of the major people-search sites. Expect to repeat it.

Who answers when you can't: four kinds

AI built into a phone system

You get the line and the AI in one app.

Quo Sona
Allo
RingCentral AIR

Standalone AI receptionist

Forward a line you already have to it.

Smith.ai AI
Goodcall
My AI Front Desk

Live human receptionist

A person answers. Billed by minute or call.

Ruby
Smith.ai live

Lead follow-up AI

Texts, emails and calls leads to qualify them.

Structurely (real estate)
CRM assistants

If you're getting a new line anyway, the first group does both jobs at once.

A closer look: Quo's Sona

What it does

- Answers inbound calls 24/7 and handles common questions
- Takes messages and asks your own intake questions
- Transfers to a person when needed
- Texts links mid-call (booking pages, forms, directions)
- Records, summarizes and logs every call

What it doesn't

- No outbound calls, inbound only
- Works only inside Quo's phone system
- Can't switch languages mid-call (English, Spanish, French)
- No live receptionist behind it
- Requires a paid Quo plan first

Source: Quo Sona page, read Nov 12, 2026

Where Sona fits

What you need	Fit	Why
Catch calls while you're with a client	**Strong**	24/7 answering, intake questions, call summaries
A new business line with no hardware	**Strong**	Quo gives you the number and the AI in one setup
One line shared by partners	**Strong**	Quo's core product is a shared inbox for calls and texts
Low cost at small volume	**Strong**	About $44 a month for one line and 40 AI calls
Leads flow into your CRM	**Weak**	HubSpot and Salesforce on Quo's Business plan; others via Zapier
A person on hard calls	**None**	AI only; it transfers to you, not to a live receptionist

Sources: Quo Sona page; Quo pricing; Zapier Quo integrations

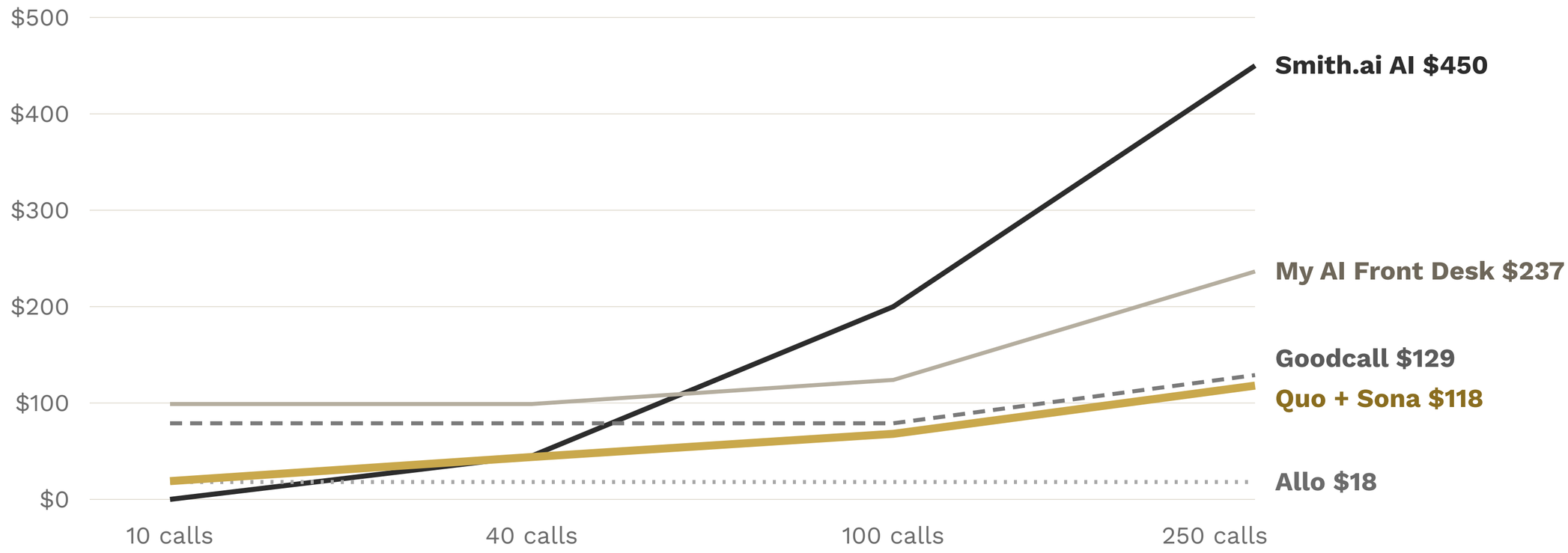
Monthly cost at 40 calls a month



One line, monthly billing, 3-minute average call. Quo $19 + $25 Sona tier. Smith.ai: 25 free calls, $3 each after. Allo at annual rate.

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What happens as call volume grows



Same assumptions. Goodcall bills per unique caller (assumed 80% of calls).

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What each option does

Option	Keep a line you have	Human backup	CRM link	Free to test
Quo + Sona	No, moves to Quo	No	HubSpot, Salesforce; others via Zapier	7-day trial after paid plan
Allo	No, moves to Allo	No	HubSpot, Pipedrive, Salesforce, Zoho	Check
Smith.ai AI	Yes, forward it	Yes, live agents	Via Zapier	25 calls/mo free
Goodcall	Yes, forward it	No	Via Zapier	14-day trial
My AI Front Desk	Yes, forward it	No	Built-in CRM	7-day trial
Ruby	Yes, forward it	Humans only	Check	No
Structurely	Not a phone answerer	No	Follow Up Boss (real estate)	No; setup fee

"Check" = not confirmed in research; ask the vendor.

Works with AI assistants like Claude and ChatGPT?

Service	Connects?	How
Quo (+ Sona)	**Yes, official**	One-click connector, included with every Quo plan
Allo	Yes	Add it yourself as a custom connector
Smith.ai	Through Zapier	Zapier passes Smith.ai actions to your assistant
Google Voice	**No**	Only the voicemail emails it sends to Gmail

What a connected assistant can do

Summarize calls and texts, flag missed callbacks, draft follow-ups, update contacts.

What it can't do

Answer or place calls. The phone agent answers; the assistant works with what it leaves.

Before you connect: the assistant sees your call transcripts. Check your clients' rules first, and keep text sending on "ask before sending."

Sources: Quo MCP docs; Allo MCP page; Zapier Smith.ai MCP

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IF YOUR CLIENTS ARE GOVERNMENT, LAW ENFORCEMENT OR UNIVERSITIES

Every AI answerer records. Know the rules first.

Maryland: everyone must consent

One of about a dozen all-party consent states. Recording without it is a felony.

Virginia and DC: one party

You can consent for yourself. But on calls across state lines, the strictest rule usually applies.

Your clients may have their own rules

Agencies and schools often limit recording and AI tools. Ask before an AI picks up their calls.

Turn on an automatic recording notice (Quo has one) and keep sensitive client calls on a person, not the AI.

Not legal advice. Sources: Justia 50-state recording survey; Ezel Maryland survey; Quo recording disclosure guide

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Answer four questions first

1

How many calls a week go to voicemail?

A handful? A good greeting and auto text-back may be enough.

2

Do you want a person behind the AI?

Smith.ai is the only AI option here with live backup.

3

Do your clients have recording or AI rules?

If yes, keep AI on general inquiries and route clients to you.

4

Are you growing or buying back your time?

More answered calls means more leads. Pick the tool for the goal.

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Three common setups

STARTING FRESH

Quo + Sona

New line plus AI answering in one app. About $44 a month to start; stays cheap as calls grow.

Best for: most solo builders and partners sharing a line.

WANT A PERSON IN THE LOOP

Line + Smith.ai

Get any business line, forward it to Smith.ai. Free under 25 calls, live agents for tricky calls.

Best for: client work where a wrong answer costs you.

STRICT CLIENT RULES

Line + voicemail, AI off

Business line, clear greeting, callback within a set window. Add AI later for general inquiries only.

Best for: government, law enforcement and campus clients.

Run a two-week test

Day 1	Write the script: greeting, the questions every caller gets, when to transfer, and the recording notice.
Days 2 to 14	Turn it on for after hours and client meetings only. Read every call summary.
Track	Calls caught, callers who hung up on the AI, hours you got back.
Day 15	Keep it, switch services or drop it. Decide on the numbers, not the demo.

Sources

- Quo: Sona AI agent
- Quo: plan pricing
- Quo: call recording disclosure
- Offlist: data removal and privacy
- FTC: SIM card swap guidance
- Fairshake: SIM swap fraud guide
- BAM: NAR 2024 safety report findings
- Justia: 50-state recording law survey
- Ezel: Maryland recording consent
- Allo: AI receptionists compared (vendor-written)
- Beside: Smith.ai pricing tiers
- Carly: Ruby pricing
- Goodcall pricing breakdown
- My AI Front Desk pricing breakdown
- Structurely 2026 pricing
- Quo: AI assistant connector
- Allo: AI assistant connector
- Zapier: Smith.ai connector

Questions from Between Keys. Research and explanations by my AI assistant. Prices change often; confirm with each vendor.